

20 The modern world and Australia

20.1 Overview

Numerous **videos** and **interactivities** are embedded just where you need them, at the point of learning, in your learnON title at www.jacplus.com.au. They will help you to learn the content and concepts covered in this topic.

After the horrors of World War I, how did the world change?

20.1.1 Links with our times

In 2008, the world experienced the global financial crisis (GFC), resulting in millions suffering ongoing unemployment in some of the world's richest countries. This led to calls for more control over economic activities to prevent it ever happening again.

Across much of the developed world, the decade after World War I was a time of growing prosperity. In the United States the 'Roaring Twenties' seemed to be a period of rapid, unstoppable growth of wealth. But, like during the GFC in 2008, people's expectations and hopes came crashing down with the collapse of the world economy in 1929 and the beginning of the Great Depression.

In the decades following the Depression deep social divisions arose and people saw the rise of the competing ideologies of communism and fascism. And while World War I was called 'the war to end all wars', just 20 years after the signing of peace treaties that officially brought the war to an end, the world was once again at war — this time it would be on an even more catastrophic scale.

SOURCE 1 The Great Depression in the early 1930s, led many workers to travel great distances in search of work.



on Resources



eWorkbook

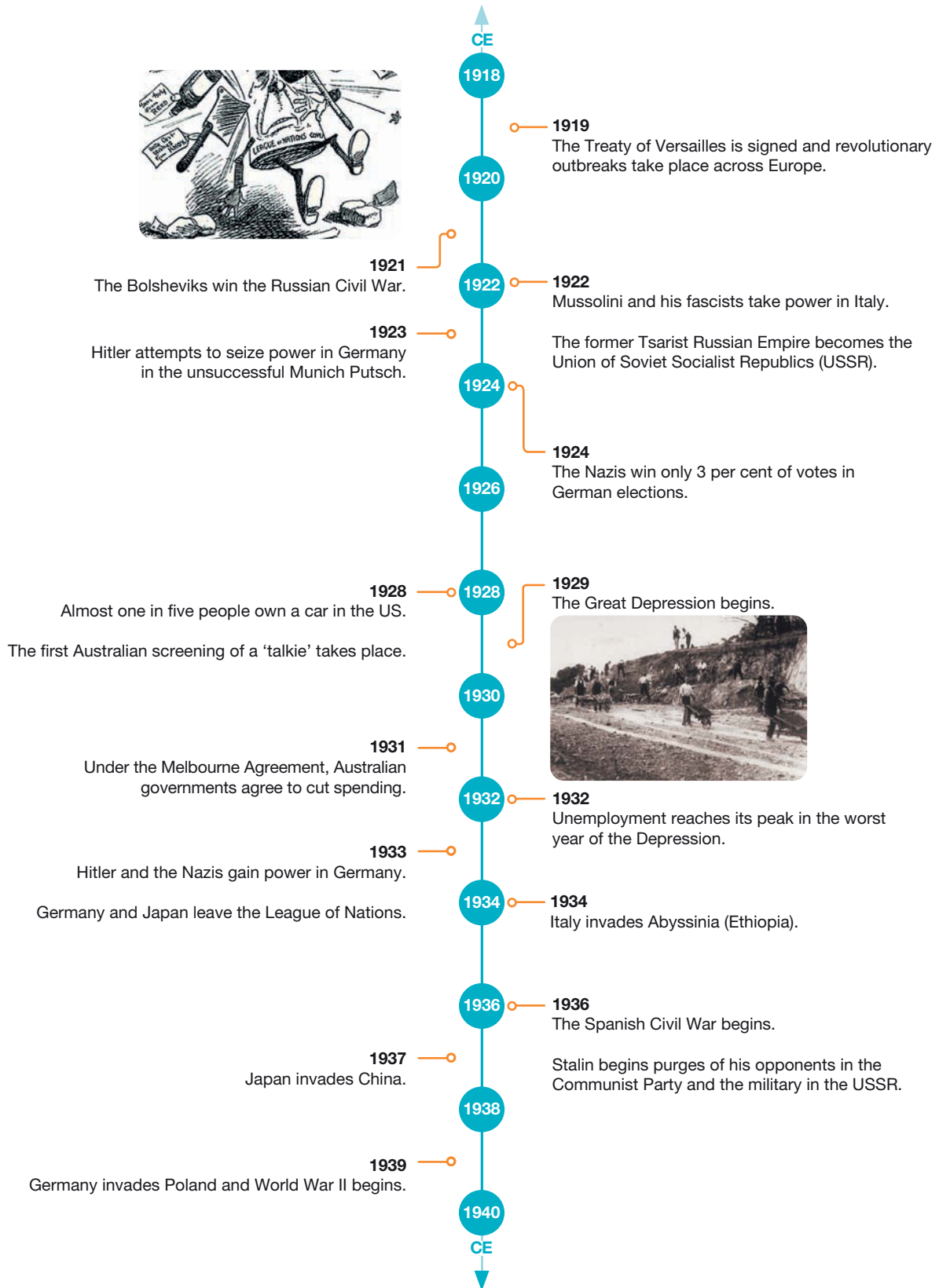
Customisable worksheets for this topic (ewbk-6329)



Video eLesson

The inter-war years (eles-2598)

SOURCE 2 A timeline of the modern world, 1918–1939



20.2 Examining the evidence

LEARNING INTENTION

By the end of this subtopic you will be able to describe the wide range of sources that provide evidence on the history of the decades between the world wars.

20.2.1 How do we know about the inter-war years?

In this topic we will survey some of the big political, economic and social changes that shaped the world and Australia between the end of World War I in 1918 and the outbreak of World War II in 1939. The most significant changes include the growing influence of communism, the unprecedented economic crisis of the Great Depression and the rise of fascism.

We have an enormous number and variety of primary sources for the period often described as the inter-war years — that is, the period of history between World War I and World War II. These sources include those created by governments, the mass media and individuals. When considered together, these sources give historians a comprehensive picture of what it was like to live in the inter-war years and experience the changes that characterised the period.

Official sources

By this period, governments and parliaments were keeping thorough records of their decisions, policies and debates. Public servants were also required to keep records. So, for most countries, we have official records of matters related to trade, health, employment, housing, foreign policy, education and every aspect of society for which governments had responsibility. In fact, it is often possible to know more about how political parties and governments made decisions then than about political decision making today. In Australia, for example, the records of Cabinet meetings (top-level meetings of governments) are kept secret for 30 years, and many other countries have similar rules.

Mass media

In most countries there were far more daily newspapers published during this period than there are today. Political parties of all kinds also published their own newspapers to spread their views. Back issues of newspapers provide day-to-day reports and images of events from those times, but they are not always reliable sources. Photography had also become more widely used.

SOURCE 1 A group of Americans eat lunch on the running board of a Model T Ford during the 1920s. By then mass production had enabled the price of a Model T to drop to about a third of what it had been in 1909.



SOURCE 2 Japanese tanks terrorising the people of Nanjing, China. The Japanese Imperial Army slaughtered over 200 000 people between December 1937 and January 1938.



Two new forms of mass media also gained huge influence during this period. They were radio, which Australians called the ‘wireless’, and film, which many called the ‘flicks’. Film had an enormous influence. By the end of the 1920s, when Australia’s population was just 6.5 million, 2.75 million movie tickets were being sold every week. Around 95 per cent of these movies were American, and they contributed to the spread of American influences. Film also became an important medium for recording world events and social changes. And political parties were quick to recognise that film provided new opportunities for propaganda in an age when many people believed that the camera did not lie.

SOURCE 3 Three young children with their dolls sharing one bed in a Melbourne slum around 1935



Personal records

Many people who lived through the Great Depression and other events of the inter-war years kept diaries or wrote letters about their experiences. Some wrote and published memoirs, providing first-hand accounts of those times.

SOURCE 4 A charity worker’s account of poverty in the 1930s, from Greig Smith, Secretary, Charity Organisation Society, in the Melbourne *Argus*, 7 March 1931.

The other day a social worker ... visited a home in an outer suburb ... The door was opened by a neatly dressed woman who had clearly been weeping ... she broke down in a distressing manner when she told of her husband’s daily heart-breaking search for work. Two years ago he had lost a steady job ... Never since has he been able to get anything better than intermittent work — casual jobs which have become fewer as the Depression has deepened. In recent months he has walked the streets ... from early morn till setting sun in a fruitless search for a job of any kind or any duration. His clothing has become shabby, his boots are worn nearly off his feet, and his wife is well-nigh distracted as daily she sees his spirit slowly breaking. The children are hungry, their clothing is threadbare, and the loss of the home is an imminent probability.

20.2 EXERCISE

To answer questions online and to receive **immediate feedback** and **sample responses** for every question, go to your learnON title at www.jacplus.com.au.

Learning pathways

LEVEL 1

Questions
1, 2, 5, 6

LEVEL 2

Questions
4, 7, 8

LEVEL 3

Questions
3, 9, 10

Check your understanding

1. Why can we often learn more about government decisions in the inter-war years than those of today?
2. Why do we have more newspaper sources for this period than for the present?
3. What were three of the most significant changes that took place between 1918 and 1939?
4. List four areas of government responsibility during the inter-war years for which we have evidence from official records.
5. What two new forms of mass media gained much influence during the inter-war years?

Apply your understanding

6. If the people in **SOURCE 1** were first-time car owners, as almost 20 per cent of Americans were at this time, how do you think they would feel about the age they were living in and about their future prospects?
7. Look closely at **SOURCE 2**. What evidence does it provide of Japanese aggression in China?
8. Study **SOURCE 3**.
 - a. Describe what you see in the image.
 - b. How useful is the source as evidence of poverty in the 1930s?
9. Read **SOURCE 4**.
 - a. What has happened to the family?
 - b. How do you think the family members would feel about their situation?
10. Using the four sources in this subtopic, write a short paragraph describing some general features of the changes that took place in the 1920s and 1930s.

For sample responses to every question, go to www.jacplus.com.au.

20.3 The peace treaties and the League of Nations

LEARNING INTENTION

By the end of this subtopic you will be able to:

- explain how the harsh terms of the peace treaties after World War I were contributing causes of World War II
- describe how the weaknesses of the League of Nations prevented it from stopping World War II.

20.3.1 The peace treaties

On 11 November 1918, the German government accepted an **armistice** that ended all fighting in World War I. German troops were exhausted and their morale was broken. The army had run out of reserves, many German people were starving and food supplies were low. The Allies had won the war but they now had the task of creating peace. Would they make treaties that took revenge for Allied losses and suffering or would they seek a peace that would last?

Five million Allied troops had died to achieve victory in World War I. Another 13 million had been wounded, many of them permanently disabled. The financial cost was also enormous, and France had suffered the destruction of farmland as well as entire towns and villages. Germany and the other Central Powers had also suffered terribly. They had lost 3.5 million troops and another 8 million were wounded. However, as many people on the Allied side saw it, the Central Powers, especially Germany, had caused the war and should be made to pay.

The Treaty of Versailles

On 28 June 1919, after five months of negotiations, delegates from the Allied countries and Germany signed the Treaty of Versailles. Germany's National Assembly regarded many of the terms set out in the treaty's 440 articles as so harsh that at first they refused to sign. Penalties imposed on Germany included restrictions on the size of its military forces as well as **reparations** payments to the **Allies** and loss of territory.

armistice a ceasefire or truce that ends fighting in a conflict, so terms for permanent peace can be discussed

reparations payments of money or materials by a nation defeated in war, as compensation for damage caused

Allies Britain, France and the other states on the winning side in World War I

SOURCE 1 The ruins of the Cloth Hall in Ypres, Belgium, in 1917. This structure was devastated by artillery fire during World War I.



Source: AWM E00720.

Territorial losses

All German overseas colonies were seized. The provinces of Alsace and Lorraine were returned to France. German territory in the east was given to Poland, and **plebiscites** were to be held in German East Prussia and Silesia to enable their people to choose between remaining part of Germany or being absorbed into Poland. The German Rhineland was to be occupied for 15 years.

Military and economic terms

Military terms: Germany was permitted to maintain a volunteer army of no more than 100 000, but it was not allowed to use conscription or to possess an air force or submarines. Its navy was to be reduced in size and it was barred from manufacturing or trading in war materials.

Economic terms: Germany's rich Saar coalfields were to be controlled by France for 15 years. German railway stock and large ships were to be handed over and Germany was to build a further million tonnes of ships for the Allies. Huge quantities of coal, steel and other raw materials were also to be given to the Allies. In addition, Germany was required to pay for all civilian damage suffered by the Allies. Under Clause 231, Germany had to accept blame for causing the war.

plebiscite direct vote in which electors give their opinion on an issue

mandates commission to act on behalf of the League of Nations to govern a people considered not ready to govern themselves

The other peace treaties

Each of the other defeated Central Powers was also made to sign a treaty.

- *The Treaty of Saint-Germain* dismantled the Austro-Hungarian Empire and required Austria to pay reparations. The south-western parts of the empire were united with Serbia and Montenegro to form the new nation-state of Yugoslavia.
- *The Treaty of Trianon* took more than 70 per cent of Hungary's territory to create the new nation-state of Czechoslovakia.
- *The Treaty of Neuilly* transferred parts of Bulgaria's territory to Greece, Romania and Yugoslavia.
- *The Treaty of Sevres* took away Turkey's Middle East territories. These states were divided between Britain and France to administer as League of Nations **mandates**.

SOURCE 2 A map showing how Europe was changed by the peace treaties



Source: Map by Spatial Vision.

int-6688

20.3.2 The League of Nations

Germany's Kaiser had been overthrown in a revolution in November 1918. US President Woodrow Wilson had wanted a more lenient treaty that would have strengthened democracy in Germany and created conditions more likely to preserve peace. France and Britain, however, wanted to weaken Germany and make it pay for their losses. The Treaty of Versailles created intense bitterness in Germany, but one hope for lasting peace was the formation of the League of Nations. It was Wilson's idea and when it was formed it held promise as a guardian of world peace. Had it worked, it might have made up for the weaknesses of the rest of the peace settlement.

The League's main task was to prevent wars. The Covenant of the League was approved at the Versailles Conference in 1919. At first the League had 42 member states, including Australia. It was made up of a General Assembly (of all member states) and a Council. The Assembly met once a year but the Council met more frequently to deal with urgent problems. It consisted of Permanent Members and Non-permanent Members. The major powers (Britain, France, Italy and Japan) were the Permanent Members. The Non-permanent Members were elected from the other member states.

SOURCE 3 Some Articles from the Covenant of the League of Nations

Article 8

The Members recognise the maintenance of peace requires the reduction of national armaments to the lowest point consistent with national safety.

Article 10

The Members of the League undertake to respect, and preserve against external aggression, the territorial integrity and existing political independence of all Members of the League ...

Article 11

Any war or threat of war, whether immediately affecting any of the members or not, is hereby declared a matter of concern to the Whole League, and the League shall take any action that may be deemed wise and effectual to safeguard the peace of nations.

The League also had several special organisations. For example, the Permanent Court of Justice was set up to resolve international legal disputes, the Health Organization was formed to combat epidemics and the International Labour Organization was concerned with industrial and economic problems. The peace treaties had given Allied countries, mainly Britain and France, mandates to administer Turkey's Middle Eastern territories and Germany's overseas colonies. As these territories were not considered to be colonies that belonged to those countries, the League's Mandates Commission was set up to ensure that the administering powers carried out their responsibilities.

Weaknesses of the League

The League never had the power to achieve its aim of preventing major wars. It could order parties in a conflict to negotiate in the Assembly, where aggressors could be warned. If that failed, the League could take steps such as ordering a trade embargo to hurt the aggressor nation's economy. The League could threaten military action against an aggressor. But it had no military force of its own and could not compel its members to provide forces. In any case, under the League's rules, any decision of the Council or Assembly had to be unanimous, so any country could prevent the League taking action to solve a crisis.

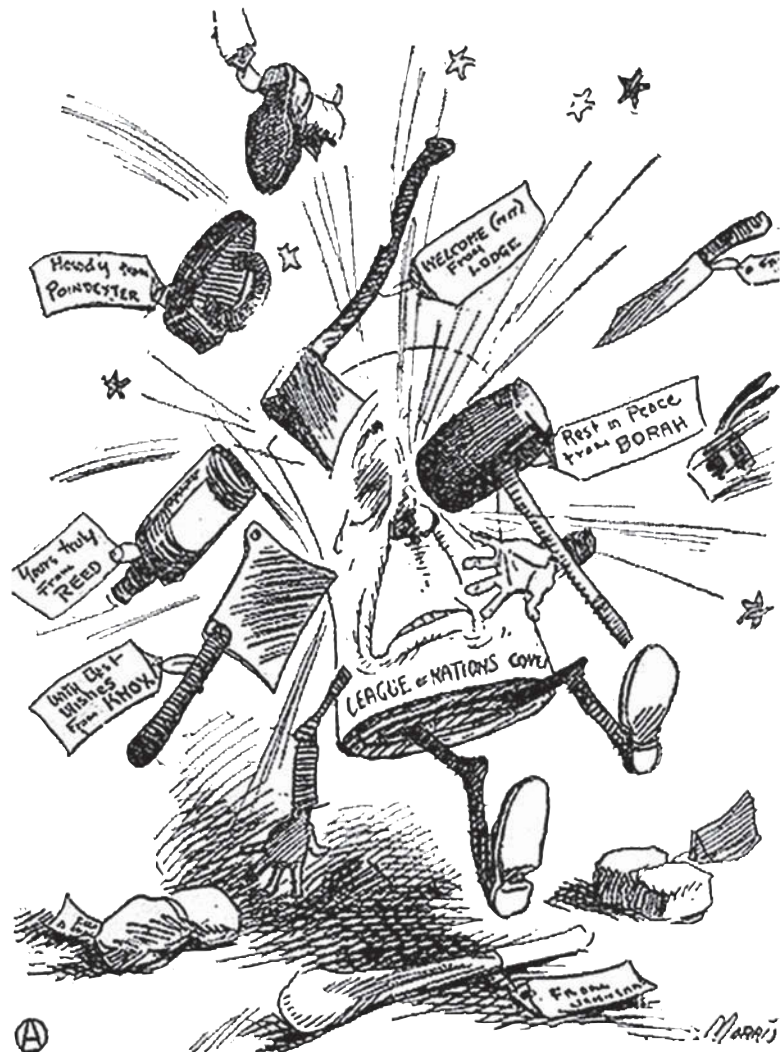
A further major weakness was that some important nations were not League members. The US Congress refused to endorse the Treaty of Versailles, so the United States did not join the League. Germany was not

allowed to join until 1926 and Russia did not join until 1934. Germany and Japan both left in 1933 and Italy quit in 1937. Despite its failure, the League was an important first attempt to design a world organisation to prevent war.

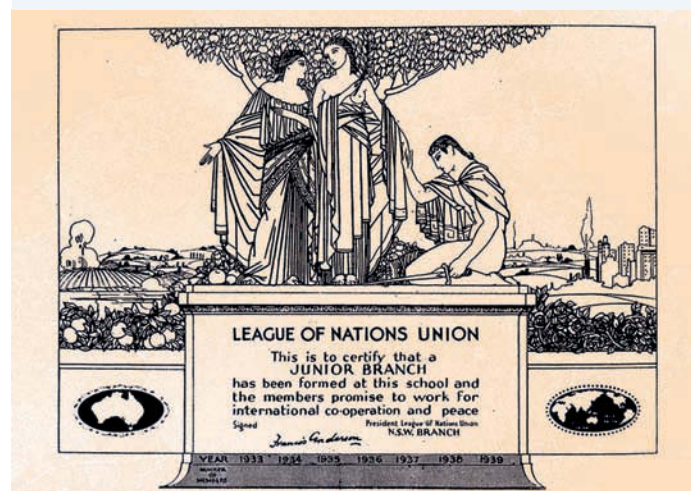
Faith in the League of Nations

After the great suffering caused by World War I, there was worldwide public support for the idealistic aims of the League. A League of Nations Union was formed to encourage people to support those aims and to counter the previously held belief that war was glorious. The League of Nations Union had branches in many countries, including Australia, where its members included politicians from the major political parties. With such support, the organisation was able to introduce League of Nations ceremonies and ideas into public schools, and junior branches formed in those schools. A special League of Nations Day was first observed in Australian schools in 1930. Such activities created great hope that there would never be another world war.

SOURCE 4 A political cartoon about the League of Nations from *Literary Digest* at the time, titled 'Can it survive?'



SOURCE 5 A League of Nations Union Junior Branch certificate, published in *Education*, the journal of the New South Wales Public School Teachers' Federation, 15 November 1934



20.3 ACTIVITY

Imagine that you are a school student in 1934. Your school has been awarded the certificate for forming a junior branch of the League of Nations Union (see **SOURCE 5**). You have been asked to give a short speech explaining why you and your fellow students are proud to be members and why your generation supports the work of the League of Nations for world peace.

Write the speech you would give. Be sure that your speech explains the significance of the formation of the League as an attempt to maintain world peace.

As a starting point, consider how important it was to people at the time, the impact it had at the time and how successful it was in meeting its aims.

History concept: Significance
HASS skills: Communicating and reflecting

20.3 EXERCISE

To answer questions online and to receive **immediate feedback** and **sample responses** for every question, go to your learnON title at www.jacplus.com.au.

Learning pathways

LEVEL 1

Questions
2, 3, 5, 6, 8, 10

LEVEL 2

Questions
1, 4, 9, 11, 12

LEVEL 3

Questions
7, 13, 14, 15

Check your understanding

1. Explain what you understand each of the following terms to mean: reparations, plebiscites, mandates.
2. Name the four treaties between the Allies and the defeated Central Powers.
3. Explain why Germany's National Assembly at first refused to sign the Treaty of Versailles.
4. Write a short summary or create a graphic organiser to show the military and economic terms of the Treaty of Versailles.
5. What became of Turkey's Middle Eastern territories under the Treaty of Sevres?
6. Whose idea was the League of Nations?
7. Which major nations were not League members and how would this have weakened the League?
8. Which countries were Permanent Members of the Council of the League of Nations?

Apply your understanding

For help with analysing cartoons, go to the SkillBuilder in topic 9 History concepts and skills.

9. Describe what you see in **SOURCE 1** and explain how it helps you to understand why there was strong support for a very harsh treaty with Germany.
10. Using **SOURCE 2** as your evidence, describe the territorial losses suffered in Europe by:
 - a. Germany
 - b. Austria-Hungary
 - c. Bulgaria
 - d. the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR, the former Russian Empire).
11. As the USSR was not one of the defeated powers, why do you think its territorial losses (shown in **SOURCE 2**) were endorsed by the peace treaties?
12. Using the information in this subtopic and **SOURCE 3**:
 - a. describe the main aim of the League of Nations
 - b. outline three reasons why the League of Nations had little real power to prevent wars.
13. Look closely at **SOURCE 4**.
 - a. Describe the way the League of Nations is depicted in this cartoon.
 - b. Explain the message of the cartoon.
 - c. Given that the League of Nations was a peacekeeping organisation, why is this cartoon ironic?
14. Which of the sources in this subtopic gives you the clearest evidence of why the harsh terms of the peace treaties after World War I were likely to cause further trouble in Europe? Explain your choice.

15. Supporters of the Treaty of Versailles have argued that it was less harsh than the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, which Germany imposed on the Russians when they withdrew from the war. Do you think this fact justified a harsh treaty? How fair and realistic do you think it was to expect Germany to pay huge compensation?

For sample responses to every question, go to www.jacplus.com.au.

20.4 The 'Roaring Twenties'

LEARNING INTENTION

By the end of this subtopic you will be able to explain how and why for some people the 1920s was an age of prosperity, mass consumption and new freedoms, but for others it was a time of persisting poverty, discrimination and social and political divisions.

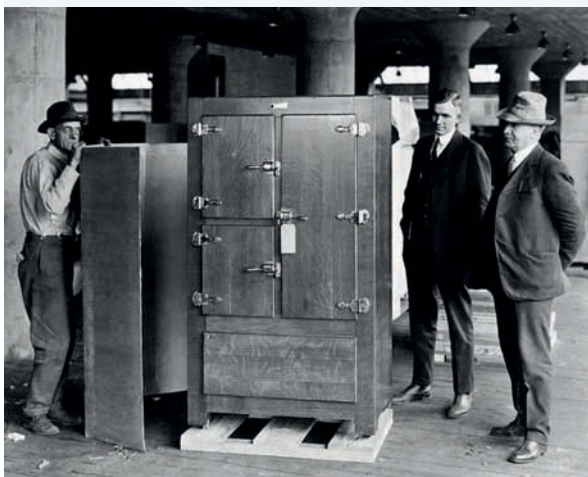
20.4.1 New technologies and changing values

During the 1920s, few people realised that forces that would bring another war were already taking shape. The decade of the 1920s has often been described as a carefree time when people put the gloom of the war years behind them. The wealth that some people had and the influence of jazz music, new dance crazes, motion pictures (movies), motorcars, new technologies and mass production all contributed to the decade being called the 'Roaring Twenties'. However, while for some it was an age of prosperity, confidence and fun, for most people around the world, the 1920s was anything but 'roaring'.

New technologies created new consumer goods. In the 1920s manufacturing was stimulated by the post-war demand for goods such as telephones, household appliances and cars (see **SOURCES 1** and **2**). The greatest growth occurred in the United States, where industrial output doubled between 1921 and 1929. How did this happen? In 1913, Henry Ford introduced the **assembly line** to manufacture his Model T automobile. Assembly lines made manufacturing much cheaper and led to big increases in production and sales. Other manufacturers soon followed Ford's example.

assembly line mass production method in which each worker completes the same operation over and over

SOURCE 1 One of the first self-contained refrigerators, made by the US company Frigidaire. The photograph was taken around 1921.



SOURCE 2 Advertisement for electrical appliances, published in *Aussie* magazine, 15 December 1920

Seasonable Gifts
A few Electrical Suggestions

CHRISTMAS and the New Year will soon be with us, and the task of selecting suitable gifts will again present itself. Illustrated here are a few practical suggestions. Electrical Appliances are excellent for presentation—they possess distinction, and the recipient will find them both useful and ornamental. In your own home, too, the addition of one or more electrical devices will afford extra comfort and convenience.

Australian General Electric Co
33-45 WENTWORTH AVENUE (MAIN) 116 QUEEN STREET, SYDNEY & 100 MELBOURNE

A visit to our showrooms will interest you, and we shall be glad at any time to demonstrate the many advantages of Electricity in the Home.

Mass-produced goods had to find mass markets, so advertising was used to encourage mass consumption. The introduction of **hire purchase** encouraged people to buy new goods because they no longer had to save up their full cost before buying. As more people bought goods, more jobs were created so even more people had money to spend. By 1929 there was one car for every five Americans; in comparison, there was only one car for every 43 people in Britain and fewer still in most of Europe.

Manufacturing also grew in Australia as British and American companies set up Australian branches. General Electric made toasters, irons and heaters and General Motors and Ford opened motor vehicle assembly plants in Australia in the mid 1920s. For those who could afford it, the consumer age had arrived. However, real wages barely improved in Australia through the 1920s.

Changing values

The mood of the 1920s was expressed through the music, fashions and entertainment. Jazz had been created by African Americans. It became widely popular in the United States and around the world, especially through musicians such as Louis Armstrong and Duke Ellington. New dances such as the Charleston were performed at music halls and dance clubs. The United States had introduced **prohibition** in 1920 and it remained illegal to sell alcohol until 1933. But millions of Americans defied the law by drinking in illegal bars called ‘speakeasies’ that were often operated by gangsters.

People also became obsessed by aviation, which combined speed, thrills and novelty. When Bert Hinkler made his record-breaking England to Australia flight, 80 000 people turned out to cheer him as he landed in Melbourne.

Reacting to change

Women were gaining more freedom and independence in this age. Some, called ‘flappers’, shocked conservatives by wearing short dresses, smoking cigarettes and drinking alcohol in public. But many people were horrified by such changes in values and behaviour. Mixed bathing on beaches, even in neck-to-knee costumes, was seen as another sign of declining morals. Women received most blame for a suspected increase in sexual relations outside marriage. In Australia, churches warned of the evils of alcohol and called for a return to traditional values (see **SOURCE 4**).

hire purchase buying and using a product while paying for it in instalments

prohibition 1920s nationwide ban in the United States on the making, transporting or selling of alcoholic drinks

SOURCE 3 A typical ‘flapper’ of the 1920s



SOURCE 4 From the Catholic newspaper the *Freeman's Journal*, 25 March 1925

There is the sensual and barbaric music, the modern sexual dances, and alcoholic refreshments, and a general acceptance of the standards and conversation that obtain among an irresponsible and jazzing generation.

on Resources

 **Weblink** The Roaring Twenties experience

Explore more with myWorldHistoryAtlas

Deepen and check your understanding of this topic with related case studies and auto-marked questions.

- Overview > Post-world war peace

20.4.2 The other side of the 1920s

The image of the 1920s as an age of prosperity and excitement ignores the experiences of most people. In the United States, rural workers gained little and African Americans especially suffered poverty and discrimination. Although the United States had suffered much less in the war than other Allied nations, there were problems readjusting to peace. Many demobilised soldiers were unemployed while the cost of living doubled in two years. When workers went on strike for better pay they were violently suppressed.

Intolerance in the United States

African Americans, migrants and political **radicals** experienced the hatred of many white Americans. The Ku Klux Klan grew rapidly in the 1920s. By 1925 this violent racist movement had five million members (see **SOURCE 5**). It incited **lynchings** and other atrocities against black Americans and preached hatred of blacks, Catholics, Jews, non-English migrants and socialists. There were race riots in many cities.

SOURCE 5 A Ku Klux Klan initiation ceremony during the 1920s



Conservative politicians and the press convinced many Americans that there was a 'Red' conspiracy to overthrow the US. In 1919 and 1920 more than 10 000 suspected communists and **anarchists** were arrested. On 15 April 1920, two men were shot dead in a payroll robbery. Two Italian Americans, Nicola Sacco and Bartolomeo Vanzetti, were charged with these murders even though they had sound alibis and there was no evidence against them. Sacco and Vanzetti were found guilty and sentenced to death because they were anarchists. In 1925, another man confessed to being a member of the gang that carried out the killings. Despite this, Sacco and Vanzetti were executed on 23 August 1927. On that day more than 250 000 people protested in Boston.

radicals a person who advocates fundamental or revolutionary changes in current practices, conditions or institutions

lynching the execution of a person without authority or process of law

anarchists revolutionaries who want an equal society based on cooperation rather than government or coercive laws

Division in Europe

After the war there were bitter social divisions in Europe. Many French socialists believed that revolution was near. British society was also deeply divided. No longer the 'workshop of the world', Britain experienced widespread poverty and unemployment. In the early 1920s, working-class unrest was violently suppressed. Mounted police attacked hunger marches led by demobilised soldiers. In Ireland, British forces conducted a savage campaign against Irish rebels.

Italy came close to a socialist revolution after the war. Demobilised peasant soldiers seized land from wealthy landowners, while in towns and cities workers took over the factories. The rich and the middle classes, who feared that Italy would follow the path of Russia, turned to the fascists to save them. Similar conflicts erupted in Germany and parts of the former Austro-Hungarian Empire.

Unrest in the colonies

Independence movements grew in many colonies of the European powers immediately after the war. Many revolutionaries were inspired by the example of the Russian Revolution. In 1919 in the Dutch East Indies (modern Indonesia) the Islamic Union called for independence. In 1920 the Indies Communist Party was formed. It attempted an uprising against the Dutch in 1926–27, but its leaders were hanged and thousands of others were imprisoned. In French Indochina, the French Foreign Legion terrorised the people to crush dissent against French rule. But the Legion's brutality drove many Vietnamese to support movements such as the Viet Nam Quoc Dan Dang, which was formed in 1927 to fight for Vietnam's independence (see **SOURCE 6**).

SOURCE 6 An eyewitness description of the behaviour of troops of the French Foreign Legion in Indochina during the 1920s, from Walter G. Langlois, *Andre Malraux: The Indochina Adventure*, London, 1966

An unleashed soldiery ... now terrorises the entire country. They steal, rape, condemn to death, and execute ... Legionnaires enter homes, take what catches their fancy, indulge in outrages against women and young girls. For trifles, without proof, men and youths are arrested and shot in cold blood without trial ... and the region lives under a real reign of military terror ... If it is with such methods that we intend to pacify the country, we are gravely mistaken.

DID YOU KNOW?

In British India in 1919, an unarmed Indian crowd was fired upon by troops commanded by General Reginald Dyer in the town of Amritsar. In this massacre, 372 people were killed and at least 1000 were wounded. In the following years the Indian National Congress became a mass movement dedicated to ending British rule.

DISCUSS

In groups, discuss the following topic: 'The 1920s — why we owe it a debt today'.

History concept: Significance

20.4 ACTIVITY

Study **SOURCE 5**. Use the internet to prepare a report on the racist activities of the Ku Klux Klan during the 1920s. Explain how its extreme ideology was similar to that of European fascist movements. For help starting your research, see topic 1 HASS skills.

History concepts: Source, Evidence

20.4 EXERCISE

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Learning pathways

LEVEL 1

Questions
1, 4, 5, 6, 8

LEVEL 2

Questions
2, 3, 9, 10

LEVEL 3

Questions
7, 11, 12, 13

Check your understanding

1. What is an assembly line?
2. Describe the impact in the United States of mass production and hire purchase.
3. Describe the social changes that led to the 1920s being called the 'Roaring Twenties'.
4. Identify the groups in the United States who suffered poverty, intolerance and discrimination during the 1920s.
5. Explain why there was deep division and conflict in Europe and the United States during the 1920s.
6. Describe the responses of Dutch, British and French colonial powers to independence movements in their colonies.
7. Why might oppressed groups generally have considered this period to be anything but the 'Roaring Twenties'?

Apply your understanding

8. Look at the appearance of the refrigerator in **SOURCE 1**. Describe ways in which it differs from a modern refrigerator and explain what differences such an appliance would have made to people's lives.
9. Study **SOURCE 2**.
 - a. Describe the aim of this advertisement.
 - b. To what aspirations is it appealing?
 - c. Explain what this source tells us about new technologies, marketing and consumers in the 1920s.
10. Explain how **SOURCES 3** and **4** can be used as evidence of conflicting values in the 1920s.
11. Explain how **SOURCE 6** provides evidence of reasons why colonised peoples resisted European rule after World War I.
12. Referring to the sources in this subtopic, identify ways in which the 1920s was a decade of change and ways in which it was a period of reaction to change.
13. Write a brief paragraph in which you consider how accurately the term 'Roaring Twenties' describes the decade of the 1920s.

For sample responses to every question, go to www.jacplus.com.au.

20.5 The Great Depression

LEARNING INTENTION

By the end of this subtopic you will be able to:

- explain how and why the Great Depression was a time of mass unemployment, poverty, and social and political divisions
- identify how this would contribute to the rise of political extremism.

20.5.1 The coming of the Great Depression

There are reasons to believe that World War II might not have occurred but for the Great Depression. Problems had been developing in the world economy since at least the mid-1920s and in October 1929 the New York **stock exchange** collapsed (see **SOURCE 1**). Panicking investors sold shares as prices continued to fall. By the end of

stock exchange a place where stocks (shares in companies) are bought and sold

December 1929, \$40 billion had been wiped off the value of US shares. Many shareholders, **stockbrokers** and business owners lost everything. The effects of the crash spread rapidly. Millions of people lost their jobs and the world was plunged into its worst crisis since World War I. This was the Great Depression and for many people it was worse than the war.

SOURCE 1 Traders gather in growing panic outside the New York Stock Exchange on 24 October 1929.



Two problems arose from the enormous growth in production of goods and prices of shares in the United States during the 1920s. First, companies produced more goods than they could sell, while most Americans were too poor to buy them and many products could not find foreign markets. The second problem was speculation: investors used borrowed money to buy shares, expecting to sell them for quick profits when share prices rose. By the late 1920s this had caused share prices to reach unrealistic levels. When investors lost confidence and rushed to sell shares, their prices collapsed.

The result was a huge fall in demand for goods and services, so production was cut and employees were sacked. As unemployment levels rose, people spent less and more jobs were lost. Banks closed and poverty spread (see **SOURCE 2**). Millions of desperate Americans wandered the country seeking any work they could find. Because the United States was the most important centre of the world economy, the Depression quickly spread to other countries.

stockbroker someone whose job is to buy and sell shares on behalf of others

SOURCE 2 An extract from the *New Republic* by Edmund Wilson, 1933, showing poverty during the Depression

There is not a garbage-dump in Chicago which is not diligently haunted by the hungry. Last summer [in] the hot weather, when the smell was sickening and the flies were thick, there were a hundred people a day coming to one of the dumps ... A widow who used to do housework and laundry, but now had no work at all, fed herself and her fourteen-year-old son on garbage. Before she picked up the meat, she would always take off her glasses so that she couldn't see the maggots.

Germany was hit particularly hard. Its industry depended on foreign loans, as did the German government to meet reparations payments. By 1929 the German economy had only just reached its pre-war levels. Foreign loans dried up and German exports collapsed. By 1932, six million Germans were unemployed.

DID YOU KNOW?

Extremes of wealth and poverty helped to trigger the Great Depression. During the 1920s, the 36 000 wealthiest families in the United States received as much income as all of the 12 million people in the nation's poorest families. Low-paid workers could not afford to buy the goods produced in US factories. Today, the top 20 per cent of US households has more than 90 per cent of the country's financial wealth; economic inequality remains an enormous problem.

The Great Depression in Australia

Australians had experienced some of the changes associated with the 'Roaring Twenties', such as Hollywood movies, new fashions, and jazz and dance music, but unemployment reached 11 per cent during the decade and there was much industrial conflict, including a police strike in Melbourne in 1923. Australia had not had a booming economy during the 1920s, but it was among the nations that were hardest hit by the Depression.

To understand why Australia was badly affected, we need to look at how the economy was structured. Australia's prosperity was based on high prices for increasing exports of primary products and the inflow of foreign investment. But Australia owed a large and increasing amount of interest to overseas lenders. Any big fall in exports or export prices and any reduction of overseas loan funds would cause problems.

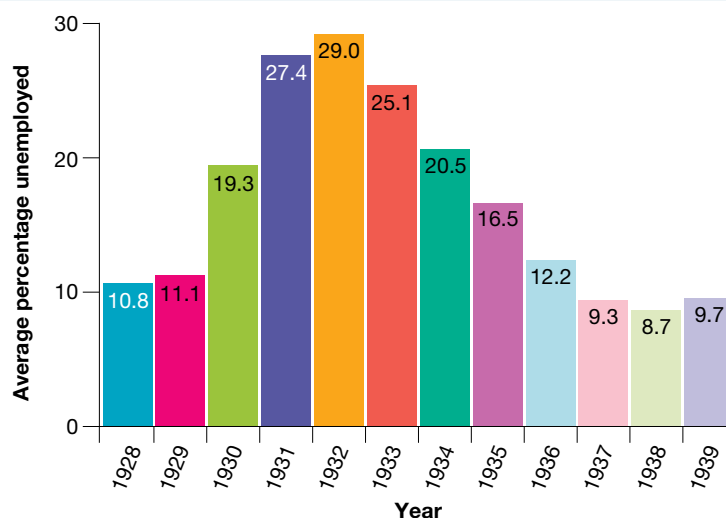
When the Great Depression struck, world prices of primary products collapsed and loan funds dried up. With loans no longer available to pay for public works and construction projects, many workers lost their jobs. This reduced demand for goods produced in other industries. By 1930 nearly 20 per cent of Australian workers were unemployed and many others had only part-time work. In 1932 unemployment reached almost 30 per cent; this figure was the same for Western Australia as for the rest of Australia.

As Australia could no longer borrow to pay for imports and keep up interest payments on debts, the Australian government raised tariffs to make imports more expensive. Australia's imports fell and exports increased, but prices for them fell so steeply that they barely increased Australia's earnings.



int-6689

SOURCE 3 Australian unemployment rates from 1928 to 1939



Source: Based on Australian Bureau of Census and Statistics, *Labour Reports*, 1920–40.

Dealing with the Depression

Because the Depression was a world problem, Australian governments felt powerless to end it. They thought they should treat their budgets in the same way a family would: when times were hard they should spend less. But as governments cut spending, more workers lost their jobs, people had less to spend and the situation worsened. At first the United States followed a similar course, but under President Roosevelt's New Deal the United States expanded **welfare** and funded public works programs that helped the country to recover.

Explore more with myWorldHistoryAtlas

Deepen and check your understanding of this topic with related case studies and auto-marked questions.

- Overview > The Great Depression

20.5.2 Living through the Great Depression

Few rich Australians were affected by the Depression, and some of them profited from it. Life went on for Australia's high society. The social pages of newspapers reported on rounds of balls, garden parties, shopping sprees and overseas trips proceeding much as they had before the Depression. In contrast, many small farmers were already in debt by 1929 as a result of droughts and falling prices. In Western Australia, despite a bumper crop of wheat in 1931, the price collapsed, leading to protests by the Wheatgrowers' Union. At first, banks evicted farmers who could not meet loan repayments, but most farmers were saved by government relief and legislation that froze their debts until conditions improved.

Workers suffered the most. At first governments relied on charities to provide for the unemployed. But charities could not deal with poverty on such a vast scale, and accepting charity was a bitter blow to people's pride. State governments provided some relief work for the unemployed but it was paid at less than the basic wage (see **SOURCE 4**). Unemployed workers were further humiliated by having to queue for the **dole** or sustenance payments, which became known as the 'susso'. Men tramped the streets in search of work. Many people went hungry, and malnourished children sometimes collapsed at school. Some people scavenged scraps from garbage bins. A survey in Melbourne found that almost 10 per cent of children suffered malnutrition and/or preventable diseases by the age of six.

In most cases no government support was provided for rent or clothing, so many faced eviction and homelessness when they could not pay their rent. Families were forced to live in shantytowns built on wasteland (see **SOURCES 5** and **7**). In these desperate times people banded together to help each other and joined demonstrations to protest against unemployment and evictions. But many felt a terrible sense of helplessness.

welfare government system to provide help to members of society who need support
dole payments to the unemployed, usually in the form of coupons to exchange for food

SOURCE 4 Unemployed workers constructing the Yarra Boulevard in Melbourne, known as 'Susso Drive', in order to receive sustenance payments during the 1930s Depression



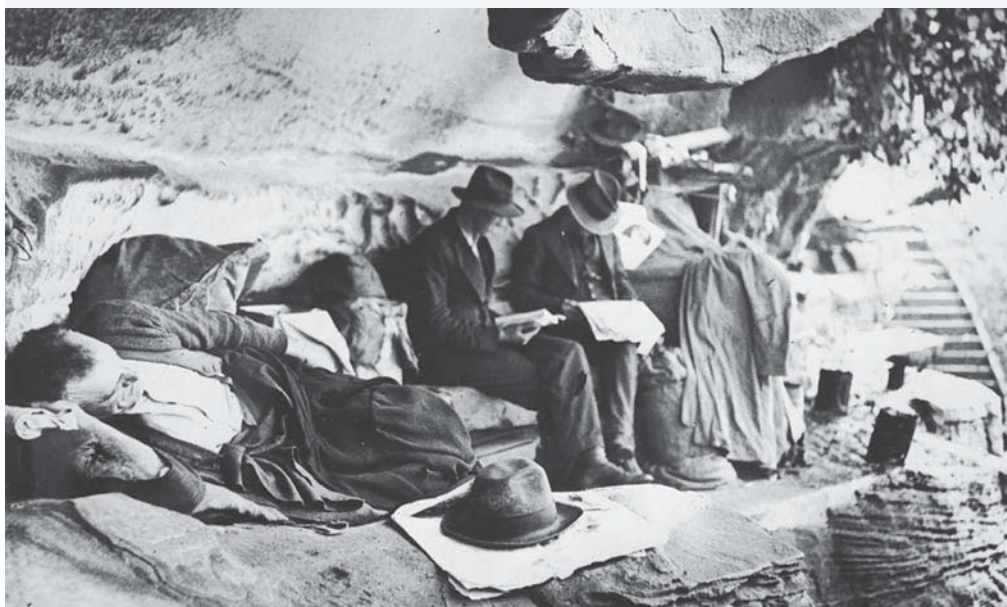
SOURCE 5 A shantytown home during the Great Depression



SOURCE 6 A newspaper article describing fierce job competition in 1930 from *The Sydney Morning Herald*, 13 February 1930

In answer to a three-line advertisement offering employment to two girls experienced in bottling and labeling, 200 girls stormed the offices of Mr Knight, toilet preparations agent ... yesterday morning. Many were well educated and carried references from leading city firms ... Some told pitiful tales of privations their families have been through owing to unemployment, and almost begged for the position.

SOURCE 7 Unemployed workers sheltering in a cave in the Sydney Domain, 25 June 1930



DID YOU KNOW?

According to the 1933 census, 40 000 Australians were living in shantytowns in makeshift shelters of old iron, canvas and other scrap materials.

Plans to help Australia through the crisis

The most radical plan was proposed by Jack Lang, the Labor premier of New South Wales. Lang wanted a temporary halt to interest payments to British lenders so more help could be given to the unemployed. All other Australian governments rejected this proposal, seeing it as an act of disloyalty to Britain.

Another plan was proposed by Labor federal treasurer E. G. Theodore. He believed that instead of cutting spending, the government should print more money to encourage spending and stimulate industry. This plan was abandoned because the banks were against it.

Instead, through the Melbourne Agreement, the Commonwealth and states agreed with the advice of Sir Otto Niemeyer, from the Bank of England, that Australian governments had to cut costs and begin to pay back their loans. In June 1931, the Commonwealth and states agreed to cut government spending, including government wages, salaries and pensions. The basic wage was reduced by 10 per cent and rates of interest on government debts were reduced. Taxes were raised to increase revenue. At the same time, the Commonwealth Bank was to provide credit to finance public works and create paid work for the unemployed.

In Australia, improvement came slowly after August 1932, but it had more to do with the recovery of the world economy than with government policies. Even in 1939 nearly 10 per cent of Australian workers were unemployed.

20.5 ACTIVITY

Working in small groups, use all the sources in this subtopic to write and perform a short play that conveys what people experienced during the Great Depression. Your script could focus on one aspect, such as unemployment and poverty. Create characters based on information gleaned from the sources. Use your imagination to add more detail about their lives before and during the Depression years.

History concepts: Source, Evidence, Empathy

HASS skills: Communicating and reflecting

20.5 EXERCISE

To answer questions online and to receive **immediate feedback** and **sample responses** for every question, go to your learnON title at www.jacplus.com.au.

Learning pathways

LEVEL 1

Questions
3, 4, 6, 10

LEVEL 2

Questions
1, 5, 7, 8

LEVEL 3

Questions
2, 9, 11

Check your understanding

1. Describe the problems that were caused in the United States by overproduction of goods and by inequality.
2. Draw a flow chart showing how each problem associated with the economic crash caused further problems.
3. Explain why Germany and Australia were particularly badly affected by the Great Depression.
4. Outline the main ideas of the three plans that were suggested to deal with Australia's economic problems.
5. Explain why some sections of society suffered greatly during the Great Depression while others hardly suffered at all.

Apply your understanding

6. Explain what you can tell about the economic crash of October 1929 from **SOURCE 1**.
7. Describe what **SOURCE 2** reveals about the desperation of unemployed Americans in 1932.
8. Referring to **SOURCE 3**, describe the trends in Australian unemployment between 1928 and 1939.
9. Imagine you are a newspaper reporter in the 1930s. Use **SOURCES 4, 5, 6 and 7** as your evidence to write a report on problems facing unemployed workers during the Great Depression.
10. Use the words provided in the box below to complete the following paragraph about the impact of the Great Depression on Australia.

export	1950s	dropped	import	employment
unemployment	rose	government	tariffs	1930s

By the mid _____, the world economy began to improve and _____ prices for Australia's wool and wheat _____. The improvement in business confidence gradually led to increased _____ and Australians were able to leave the worst of the Depression behind them. Thousands of families had battled their way through the Great Depression. At the end of it, Australians had been forced to examine their beliefs and to look more critically at their _____ and society.

11. Create a flow diagram to show how overproduction and inequality in the United States contributed to a stockmarket crash there and how the effects spread to other countries causing further consequences.

For sample responses to every question, go to www.jacplus.com.au.

20.6 Communism — dream or nightmare?

LEARNING INTENTION

By the end of this subtopic you will be able to:

- describe the rise of communism in Russia and the impacts of Stalin's brutal dictatorship
- explain how communism inspired fear and hatred among those who dreaded working-class revolt.

20.6.1 The drift to dictatorship in Russia

With the 1917 Revolution in Russia, there was an expectation among the Bolsheviks that revolutions of workers and peasants in other countries would also be triggered. In the chaos that followed the war there were several attempted revolutions in Europe. These uprisings failed but the Bolshevik Revolution continued to inspire many workers and other disadvantaged groups, especially during the hardships of the Great Depression. However, the system that developed in the USSR was not the workers' paradise that many revolutionaries had dreamed of.

The Bolshevik Revolution was based on the idea of creating a communist society in which everyone would be equal. At first the Bolshevik government, headed by Lenin, handed control of factories and other businesses to committees of workers and land was given to peasant **soviets** to redistribute. But when production slumped, the Bolsheviks appointed managers to run enterprises. To hold on to power, the Bolsheviks abolished all other political parties, including other **socialist** parties. The Bolsheviks had to be ruthless to survive, especially during the Civil War from 1918, in which they fought against armies of **White Russians**, who were aided by the armed intervention of Britain, France, the United States and Japan.

When the Civil War ended in 1921, the Bolsheviks controlled most of the former Russian Empire. In that year they crushed a revolt by sailors of the Kronstadt Naval Base who demanded an end to one-party rule. These sailors had once been among the Bolsheviks' strongest supporters. Faced with such discontent, the Bolsheviks took a temporary step backwards, relaxing economic controls. But there was no relaxation of Bolshevik political control.

SOURCE 1 A Bolshevik propaganda poster from 1920, titled 'Comrade Lenin cleans the Earth of scum'



20.6.2 Stalin's dictatorship

In 1924, Lenin died of a stroke. Joseph Stalin was the General Secretary of the Communist Party, as the Bolshevik Party was now called. Stalin used this position to outmanoeuvre his rivals, including Leon Trotsky, who had been the main organiser of the 1917 Revolution. Trotsky was exiled in 1928 and by the end of 1929 Stalin was the **USSR's** undisputed dictator.

Under Stalin's collectivisation policy, peasant farms were combined into huge collective farms between 1929 and 1935. Peasants who resisted were executed or sent to slave labour camps. Thirteen million peasants starved to death as their grain was confiscated and distributed to the cities or exported to fund the growth of manufacturing in 1932–33. In 1928, Stalin launched the first of a series of five-year plans to develop industries. The successes of these plans were achieved by harsh

soviets councils, originally elected by workers or peasants
socialist an economic system based on public ownership of industry to create greater equality
White Russians those who wanted to crush the revolution and restore the old Russian order
USSR the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, or Soviet Union, the name of the former Russian Empire from 1922

SOURCE 2 Starving children at Samara Camp during the famine in Russia. During the Civil War, under the policy called War Communism, the Bolsheviks seized grain from peasants to feed soldiers and workers. There were terrible famines and many peasant uprisings against the Bolsheviks.



SOURCE 3 From a poem in the Soviet Communist Party newspaper *Pravda* in 1931

Great Stalin, O Leader of the Peoples,
Thou who didst give birth to man,
Thou who didst make fertile the earth,
Thou who didst rejuvenate the centuries,
Thou who givest blossom to the spring,
Thou who movest the chords of harmony,
Thou splendour of my spring,
O Thou
Sun reflected in a million hearts.

workplace discipline and forced labour by political prisoners. Stalin's labour camps were soon full of such prisoners as his secret police arrested suspected **dissidents**.

In the Great Purge from 1936 to 1938, Stalin unleashed a wave of terror in which all of his critics in the Communist Party and several Red Army generals were killed. In a series of show trials, former leading Bolsheviks were forced to confess to crimes such as treason and sabotage. Russia was now a state in which people's lives were controlled by terror, strict censorship and propaganda that portrayed Stalin almost as a god.

Communism and anti-communism

Despite the horrors of Stalin's rule, the idea of communist revolution continued to find supporters in **capitalist** countries where workers were exploited and oppressed. It also inspired fear and hatred among people who dreaded any kind of working-class revolt. The ideas of communism and anti-communism would influence almost every political conflict for decades.

dissidents people who publicly disagree with government policy or actions

capitalist economic system based on private ownership of capital, free markets and competition

20.6 EXERCISE

To answer questions online and to receive **immediate feedback** and **sample responses** for every question, go to your learnON title at www.jacplus.com.au.

Learning pathways

LEVEL 1

Questions
1, 2, 3, 4, 9

LEVEL 2

Questions
5, 7, 10, 11

LEVEL 3

Questions
6, 8, 12, 13

Check your understanding

1. Describe the original measures undertaken by the Bolsheviks to give control of production to workers and peasants.
2. Explain why they soon abandoned those measures.
3. Describe how the Bolsheviks treated other political parties.

4. What event prompted the Bolsheviks to relax economic controls?
5. How did Stalin rise to power?
6. Explain the main features of the collectivisation of agriculture.
7. Describe the methods used by Stalin to eliminate his rivals, both real and potential.
8. Create a timeline of developments in post-revolution Russia to show the drift to dictatorship and the consolidation of Stalin's rule.

Apply your understanding

9. Look closely at **SOURCE 1**. Identify the sections of Russian society represented by each of the figures Lenin is sweeping away.
10. Explain the policy of War Communism. To what extent does the **SOURCE 2** photograph provide evidence of the harsh consequences of that policy?
11. Describe the way that Stalin is portrayed in **SOURCE 3** and discuss how Soviet citizens who had pinned their hopes on the revolution might have felt about such propaganda.
12. **SOURCES 1** and **2** conjure up very different images of life under Lenin.
 - a. Which source makes its point most effectively and why?
 - b. What other types of sources would help a historian arrive at a more balanced assessment of life under Lenin?
13. Some historians have observed that, while the Bolsheviks had claimed to be establishing a society that would be based on equality and democracy, under Stalin's rule Soviet society became as unequal as it had been under the Tsars, and power had become even more concentrated. How much had really changed in the former Russian Empire? Explain your response.

For sample responses to every question, go to www.jacplus.com.au.

20.7 The rise of fascism

LEARNING INTENTION

By the end of this subtopic you will be able to:

- describe the characteristics of fascist movements
- explain why fascist movements arose in several countries in the 1920 and 1930s
- identify how fascism posed a threat to human rights and world peace.

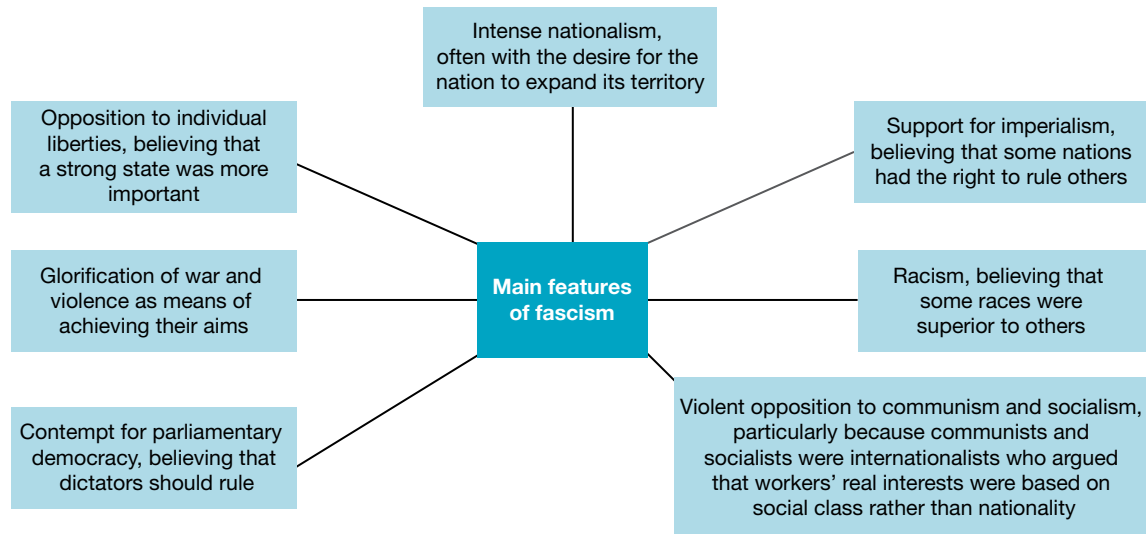
20.7.1 The nature of fascism

The Great Depression caused mass unemployment, poverty and misery around the world. But in the longer term it had even worse consequences. It led to the rise of fascism, which would present the greatest threat to human rights and world peace in the inter-war years. This extremist movement arose from the deep social divisions that followed World War I, but it gained most backing during the Depression years of the early 1930s. Support came not from those who suffered most in the Depression but from those who feared that communist or socialist workers might seize power.

Fascist movements developed in many countries in the 1920s and 1930s. While they aimed to appeal to all social classes, fascists found most support among middle-class people who feared the influence of socialism and communism. Although there were significant local differences, fascist movements shared many common characteristics (see **SOURCE 1**).

Significant fascist movements arose in the inter-war years in many European countries, including Italy, Austria, Hungary, Finland, France, Belgium, Spain, Romania and Britain. There were also fascist or extreme right movements in the United States and Australia.

SOURCE 1 Main features of fascism



SOURCE 2 In ancient Rome, the annually elected leader carried a bundle of sticks wrapped around an axe. It was called the *fasces* and it symbolised strength and power. Mussolini revived it in 1919 as the symbol of Italian fascism.



20.7.2 Fascism in Italy

Italy was the first country in which fascists gained power. During World War I there had been heavy fighting in Italy's own territory. The war's end brought rising prices, high unemployment and nationalist resentment that Italy had not gained more from the peace treaties. Italy experienced great social conflict after the war. Its strong communist movement was inspired to follow the example of the Bolsheviks in Russia and **foment** a revolution.

However, by 1919 fascism was also a powerful movement in Italy. Italian fascist thugs, called 'blackshirts', fought trade unionists, socialists and communists in street battles. Fascists bashed their political opponents and burned the offices of newspapers that dared to criticise them. They gained support from the middle classes and the rich by violently breaking up strikes. In 1922, their leader, Benito Mussolini (see **SOURCE 5**), organised a fascist march on the capital, Rome. The Italian king regarded Mussolini as an ally against the communists and socialists and invited him to become prime minister.

Once Mussolini was in power, he suspended elections and banned other political parties. Mussolini was now a dictator. As Il Duce (the leader) he turned Italy into the world's first fascist state. Workers' rights were destroyed while employers were protected. Mussolini dreamed of recreating the might of ancient Rome. Fascists controlled the mass media and the education system and they used them to **indoctrinate** a generation.

foment encourage or foster (rebellion)
indoctrinate to teach or instruct in a way that is almost brainwashing

SOURCE 3 Education was used as a powerful tool of indoctrination in fascist Italy. This extract from a compulsory textbook issued to eight-year-olds argues the need for blind obedience and loyalty to the leader.

The eyes of the Duce are on every one of you. No-one can say what is the meaning of that look on his face. It is an eagle opening its wings and rising into space. It is a flame that searches out your heart to light there a fire. Who can resist that burning eye, darting out its arrows? But do not be afraid; for you those arrows will change into rays of joy. A child, who, even while not refusing to obey, asks 'Why?', is like a bayonet made of milk ... 'You must obey because you must,' said Mussolini, when explaining the reasons for obedience.

DID YOU KNOW?

Although all fascist movements were racist, Italian fascism was not anti-Semitic (anti-Jewish) until it came under the influence of German Nazism. When Mussolini first seized power, his Fascist Party had wealthy Jewish Italians among its supporters and members.

20.7.3 Fascism in Australia

Extreme right-wing movements in Australia included the King and Empire Alliance, which was launched in Melbourne in 1920 by conservative politicians, businessmen and ex-servicemen. Its intention appears to have been to seize power if a Labor government tried to introduce socialism. Similar groups in the 1920s included the Melbourne-based White Guard and the Sane Democracy League. During the Depression era, more organisations of this nature emerged in Australia and several of them formed secret armies to fight any threat of socialism.

The New Guard movement

The best known and largest of these Australian groups was the New Guard. It was formed in 1931 and at its peak had 36 000 members. It was strongly influenced by fascist movements in Europe, and it attracted many middle-class supporters. Its leader, Eric Campbell, was an admirer of Mussolini. The New Guard fought street battles with Labor and Communist supporters. At the opening of the Sydney Harbour Bridge in 1932, a mounted New Guard member, Frances De Groot, succeeded in cutting the ribbon ahead of Labor premier Jack Lang. Slashing the ribbon with his sword, he declared the bridge open 'in the name of the decent and respectable people of New South Wales'. De Groot had fought with the 15th Hussars on the Western Front in World War I, when he earned his sword. De Groot's upstaging of Lang at the ceremony was not only a security blunder, it also gave the New Guard strong publicity.

SOURCE 4 Frances De Groot, on horseback and in military uniform, uses his sword to cut the ribbon at the opening of the Sydney Harbour Bridge in 1932.



The New Guard even planned to overthrow the Lang government in New South Wales. An armed revolt was avoided when the New South Wales governor dismissed Lang from office in May 1932. However, support for such extremist movements declined quickly as Australia recovered from the Depression.

20.7.4 Fascism in Germany and Spain

The most significant result of the rise of fascism was felt in Germany. At the end of World War I the country was bitterly divided. Following the abdication of the Kaiser, Germany became a democratic republic. However, the German Spartacists (communists) wanted to follow the Bolsheviks' example and establish a socialist republic based on workers' soviets. The moderate socialists wanted to reform Germany through parliamentary democracy.

The republic was first threatened when the left attempted a Bolshevik-style revolution in 1919. But a much greater danger came from the extreme right. Fascist groups, composed mostly of ex-soldiers, blamed

Germany's defeat and humiliation on socialists, communists and Jews. The government used groups of fascist ex-soldiers, called *Freikorps*, armed with artillery, machine guns, grenades and flame-throwers, to crush the Spartacist uprisings of 1919.

In March 1920, these fascist ex-soldiers tried to seize power in the Kapp **Putsch**, but they were thwarted by resistance from the German socialist trade unions. The next fascist attempt to seize power was made by Adolf Hitler, who had become the leader of the National Socialist German Workers' (Nazi) Party in 1921. Hitler first attempted to seize power in the Munich Putsch of 1923. The putsch was defeated. Hitler's rise was then delayed by growing German prosperity during the late 1920s. Hitler consolidated his position in the party, building up his private armies and refining terror tactics and propaganda. Eventually, the Nazi rise to power was made possible by the Great Depression. In just ten turbulent years following the Munich Putsch, Hitler's Nazis were to gain control of Germany and lead the country towards another world war.

SOURCE 5 Mussolini (left), giving the fascist salute, with Adolf Hitler on a visit to Germany in 1937. The swastika (on Hitler's sleeve) was adopted as the symbol of Nazism.



Fascism in Spain

Fascists also gained power in Spain. In 1936, General Francisco Franco and other Spanish military leaders started a rebellion against Spain's democratically elected republican government. In the three-year Spanish Civil War, Franco was supported by the Spanish fascists (Falange), the wealthy Spanish landowners, the leaders of the Catholic Church, Spanish monarchists and, most importantly, forces from Fascist Italy and Nazi Germany. The German Luftwaffe (air force) used Spain to test the tactics they would later use in World War II.

The Spanish Republic received some assistance from the Soviet Union and Mexico and from idealistic international volunteers (see **SOURCE 6**), including about 60 Australians. However, Franco triumphed. This was partly because of the assistance provided by Hitler and Mussolini and partly because the Western democracies turned a blind eye to fascist aggression while preventing much aid from reaching the Spanish Republic. With Franco's victory in 1939, Spain became another fascist dictatorship.

SOURCE 6 A group of British anti-fascist volunteers who fought in Spain in 1936



Source: Tom Mann Centuria Inglesa Antifascista. From the collection of the Noel Butlin Archive Centre.

Putsch an attempt to seize political power by force

20.7 EXERCISE

To answer questions online and to receive **immediate feedback** and **sample responses** for every question, go to your learnON title at www.jacplus.com.au.

Learning pathways

LEVEL 1

Questions
1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 7, 8, 13

LEVEL 2

Questions
5, 9, 10, 11, 14, 15, 19

LEVEL 3

Questions
12, 16, 17, 18, 20, 21

Check your understanding

1. Among which social class did fascism find the most support?
2. What fears drove many members of that class to support fascism?
3. What factors in Italy after World War I created conditions for change?
4. Who were the 'blackshirts' and how did they behave?
5. What means did fascists in Italy use to influence Italian society?
6. Describe the tactics used by Mussolini to gain power in Italy.
7. Name some right-wing movements active in Australia in the 1920s.
8. Which social classes in Australia were attracted to these right-wing movements?
9. Why did support decline after the Depression?
10. In what way did the New Guard gain attention?
11. Describe two unsuccessful attempts by German fascists to seize power in the 1920s.
12. With whose assistance did fascism triumph in Spain by 1939?

Apply your understanding

For help with analysing sources, go to the SkillBuilder in topic 9 History concepts and skills.

13. How would you classify **SOURCE 1**? Is it a historical source? Explain.
14. Referring to **SOURCE 1**, write a brief description of the main features of fascism.
15. Describe the Italian fascist symbol in **SOURCE 2** and identify reasons why Italian fascists would have chosen a symbol from ancient Rome.
16. Analyse **SOURCE 3** using the following questions:
 - a. Who would have produced the textbook from which this extract is taken?
 - b. For what readers was it intended?
 - c. Why was such material produced?
 - d. What beliefs and values was it attempting to instil?
 - e. How effective might it have been as propaganda in a situation where fascists also controlled the mass media?
17. Study **SOURCE 4**.
 - a. Why do you think De Groot took this action? Consider his own words to help you with your answer.
 - b. What aspects of this image might be considered frightening or alarming to a member of the Australian public at that time if they saw it in a newspaper?
18. Describe the dress of both fascist leaders in **SOURCE 5** and explain what aspect of their ideology would have led them to wear military-style outfits.
19. **SOURCE 6** provides a clue as to why some British volunteers went to Spain to fight fascism in the 1930s. Support for what political ideal is represented in the source?
20. Why did fascism appeal to people during the 1920s and 1930s? If similar economic conditions existed today, do you believe that fascist movements could gain popularity? Explain.
21. Using the sources and other information in this subtopic, evaluate the historical significance of the rise of fascism. In your answer you should consider its influence at the time, how many people and countries were affected, and its consequences.

For sample responses to every question, go to www.jacplus.com.au.

20.8 Thinking Big research project: TV Quizmaster

20.8.1 Scenario

Because you are a historian specialising in the World War II period, the producers of a television quiz show have commissioned you to prepare multiple-choice questions for a contestant whose special subject is Japan from 1894 to 1941, particularly the rise of extreme nationalism and militarism in Japan from the late nineteenth century, the similarities between Japanese ultra-nationalism and European fascist movements, and Japanese aggression that contributed to Japan joining the fascist powers in World War II.

20.8.2 Task

You are to research and write 12 multiple-choice questions that will be used in the quiz show, ensuring that your questions cover the following aspects of Japanese history in the period from 1894 to 1941. Ensure that you write at least one multiple-choice question on each of the following:

- The Sino-Japanese war of 1894–95
- Japan's motives for siding with the Allies in World War I
- How the Great Depression contributed to the rise of extreme nationalism and militarism in Japan
- Japanese military aggression in Manchuria and northern China from 1932
- The similarities between Japanese ultra-nationalism and European fascism
- The Rome–Berlin–Tokyo Axis
- The Rape of Nanjing
- Why Japan confined its aggression to China until 1941
- Where Japanese aggression occurred in 1941
- Why Japan attacked Pearl Harbour in 1941

SOURCE 1 Japanese soldiers celebrate the capture of Nanjing, China



20.8.3 Process

- Open the ProjectsPLUS application in the Resources for this topic. Open the **Project set-up** tab to enter the project due date and set up your project group so you can work collaboratively. Working in groups of two will enable you to swap ideas and share responsibility for the project. Save your settings and the project will be launched.
- Navigate to the **Research forum**, where you will find starter topics (the dot points in the task section) loaded to guide your research. You can add further topics to the Research forum if you wish.
- Start by revisiting the content in subtopics 20.7 The rise of fascism (You could also look ahead to topic 21, subtopics 21.4 Japanese militarism and 21.6 Overview of World War II to 1944.)
- Supplement your knowledge by conducting further research using the library or the internet. The weblinks in the **Media centre** will provide a useful starting point. Remember to record details of your sources so you can create a bibliography to submit with your quiz questions.
- Add your research notes and source details to the relevant topic pages in the Research forum. You can view, share and comment on research findings with your partner. When you have completed your research, you can print out the **Research report** in the Research forum to easily view all the information you have gathered, if you wish.
- When you are satisfied with your research, write your 12 multiple-choice questions. You should provide four possible responses, and identify the correct answer, for each question. Ensure that your questions are difficult enough to challenge the quiz contestant!
- Submit your multiple-choice questions and your bibliography to your teacher for assessment and feedback.

SOURCE 2 Stricken US battleships during the attack on Pearl Harbour



Resources



projectsPLUS Thinking Big research project: TV Quizmaster (pro-0204)

20.9 Review

20.9.1 Key knowledge summary

20.2 Examining the evidence

- We have vast amounts of sources for this period.
- Sources include official records, mass media reports and personal records such as diaries, letters and memoirs.

20.3 The peace treaties and the League of Nations

- At the peace conferences after World War I, harsh terms were imposed by the victors on the defeated powers; this caused great bitterness.
- The League of Nations offered the only hope of preventing further wars but it lacked any effective powers to stop aggression.

20.4 The 'Roaring Twenties'

- The 1920s was an age of mass production, mass consumption and changing values.
- It was also an age of intolerance, discrimination, poverty, deep social divisions and political unrest.

20.5 The Great Depression

- The 1930s depression was caused by overproduction, speculation and extreme inequality.
- It quickly spread around much of the world.
- Some countries, including Australia and Germany, were particularly badly affected.

20.6 Communism — dream or nightmare?

- The Bolshevik (communist) Revolution soon became a one-party dictatorship.
- The one-party dictatorship was turned into a one-man dictatorship under Joseph Stalin.
- Although it had turned into a nightmare in the USSR, the communist dream continued to find followers in the capitalist world.

20.7 The rise of fascism

- Fascism first came to power in Italy.
- This ideology was violently nationalist, racist, anti-communist, anti-socialist and anti-democratic.
- Fascist movements formed in many countries, including Australia, Germany and Spain.

20.9.2 Key terms

Allies Britain, France and the other states on the winning side in World War I

anarchists revolutionaries who want an equal society based on cooperation rather than government or coercive laws

armistice a ceasefire or truce that ends fighting in a conflict, so terms for permanent peace can be discussed

assembly line mass production method in which each worker completes the same operation over and over

capitalist economic system based on private ownership of capital, free markets and competition

dissidents people who publicly disagree with government policy or actions

dole payments to the unemployed, usually in the form of coupons to exchange for food

foment encourage or foster (rebellion)

hire purchase buying and using a product while paying for it in instalments

indoctrinate to teach or instruct in a way that is almost brainwashing

lynching the execution of a person without authority or process of law

mandates commission to act on behalf of the League of Nations to govern a people considered not ready to govern themselves

plebiscite direct vote in which electors give their opinion on an issue

prohibition 1920s nationwide ban in the United States on the making, transporting or selling of alcoholic drinks

Putsch an attempt to seize political power by force

radicals a person who advocates fundamental or revolutionary changes in current practices, conditions or institutions

reparations payments of money or materials by a nation defeated in war, as compensation for damage caused

socialist an economic system based on public ownership of industry to create greater equality

soviets councils, originally elected by workers or peasants

stock exchange a place where stocks (shares in companies) are bought and sold
stockbroker someone whose job is to buy and sell shares on behalf of others
USSR the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics, or Soviet Union, the name of the former Russian Empire from 1922
welfare government system to provide help to members of society who need support
White Russians those who wanted to crush the revolution and restore the old Russian order

20.9.3 Reflection

Complete the following to reflect on your learning.

Revisit the inquiry question posed in the Overview:

After the horrors of World War I, how did the world change?

1. Now that you have completed this topic, what is your view on the question? Discuss with a partner. Has your learning in this topic changed your view? If so, how?
2. Write a paragraph in response to the inquiry question outlining your views.



Resources



eWorkbook Customisable worksheets for this topic (ewbk-6329)
Reflection (ewbk-6328)
Crossword (ewbk-6327)
Student Learning Matrix (ewbk-6319)



Interactivity Origins of World War II crossword (int-7661)

20.9 Review exercise

Multiple choice

1. What are two reasons why the League of Nations was weak?
 - A. The League was dominated by the United States and ignored by the USSR.
 - B. The League had no military force of its own and it could not compel members to provide military forces.
 - C. Germany and Italy never joined the League.
 - D. The League rarely held meetings and it was not interested in peace.
2. What was a financial arrangement that encouraged mass consumption in the 1920s called?
 - A. Credit cards
 - B. Advance purchase
 - C. Hire purchase
 - D. Pay-as-you-go
3. What were two factors that contributed to causing the Great Depression?
 - A. Too many goods were produced and too few people could afford to buy them.
 - B. Ordinary people had too much money and spent even more.
 - C. Henry Ford made poor quality cars and gave them away for free.
 - D. Companies produced fewer goods and charged too little for them.
4. The Great Purge of the 1930s took place in which of these countries?
 - A. Italy
 - B. Germany
 - C. Japan
 - D. The USSR

5. Which of the following were two fascist or extreme right-wing movements in Australia in the inter-war years?
 - A. The New Guard and the Sane Democracy League
 - B. The Ozzie Nazi Party and the Mussolini Fan Club
 - C. The Campbell United Party and the Adolf Admiration League
 - D. The Anti-democratic League and the Ku Klux Klan
6. Which of the following groups thwarted the fascist attempt to seize power in the Kapp Putsch in Germany in 1920?
 - A. The Catholic Church
 - B. The socialist trade unions
 - C. The German Army
 - D. The Nazi Party
7. Which two countries' governments provided aid to the Spanish Republic in the Spanish Civil War?
 - A. The United States and Portugal
 - B. France and Italy
 - C. Germany and Brazil
 - D. Mexico and the USSR

Short answer

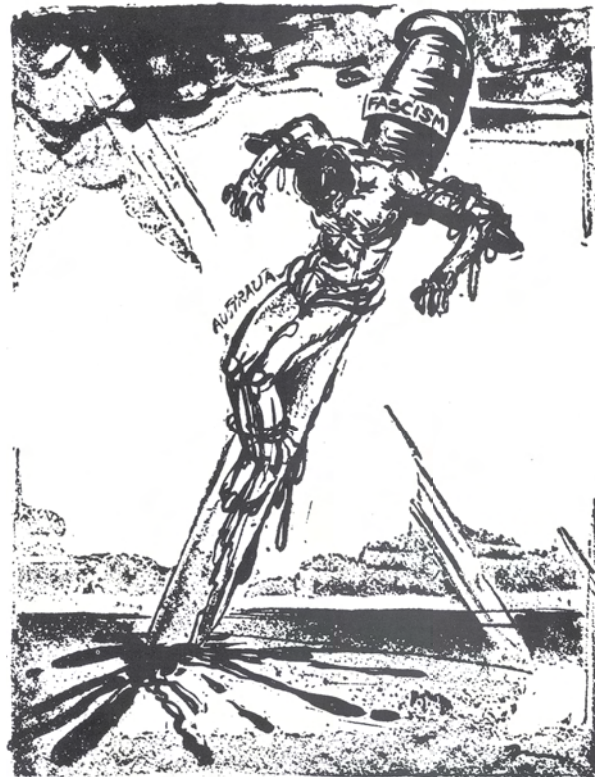
8. Analyse **SOURCE 1** using the questions that follow.
 - a. Is this a primary or secondary source?
 - b. Who or what organisation or movement created the poster?
 - c. When and where was it produced?
 - d. What is the significance of the time and place of its creation?
 - e. What was its purpose and who was it aimed at?
 - f. What is its message?
 - g. How effectively does it convey that message?

Answers to historical questions are not, of course, so simple as that stated in **SOURCE 2**.

SOURCE 2 From Eric Hobsbawm, *Age of Extremes*

The origins of the Second World War have produced an incomparably smaller historical literature than the causes of the First, and for an obvious reason. With the rarest exceptions, no serious historian has ever doubted that Germany, Japan and (more hesitantly) Italy were the aggressors. The states drawn into the war against these three, whether capitalist or socialist, did not want a war, and most of them did what they could to avoid one. In the simplest terms the question who or what caused the Second World War can be answered in two words: Adolf Hitler.

SOURCE 1 A German socialist poster for the July 1932 elections



9. Your task is to produce an argument either in support of the view that Hitler was the cause of World War II or against such a view. In your argument, you should refer to sources encountered in this topic. Questions you might consider in forming your argument could include:
 - a. Is the cause of any big event ever simple?
 - b. Would the war have occurred without Hitler?
 - c. Would Hitler have gone to war if the democracies had stood up to him earlier?
 - d. Do the politicians who advocated appeasement bear some responsibility for the war?

RESOURCE SUMMARY

This is a summary of the digital resources you will find online for topic 19 to help support your learning and deepen your understanding. When you see these icons next to an image or paragraph, go to learnON to access video eLessons, interactivities, weblinks and other support material for this topic.

20.1 Overview



Video eLesson

- The inter-war years (eles-2598)



Interactivity

- A timeline of the modern world, 1918–1939 (int-6871)

20.3 The peace treaties and the League of Nations



eWorkbook

- After the Great War (ewbk-6320)



Interactivity

- Map of how Europe was changed by the peace treaties (int-6688)



MyWorld History Atlas

- The inter-war period

20.4 The 'Roaring Twenties'



eWorkbook

- Prosperity and freedom?(ewbk-6321)



Weblink

- The Roaring Twenties experience



MyWorld History Atlas

- Post-world war peace

20.5 The Great Depression



eWorkbook

- A depressed decade (ewbk-6322)



Interactivity

- Australian unemployment rates from 1928 to 1939 (int-6689)



MyWorld History Atlas

- The Great Depression

20.6 Communism — dream or nightmare?



eWorkbook

- Communism — dream or nightmare? (ewbk-6323)

20.7 The rise of fascism



eWorkbook

- Fascism — another solution to post-war problems? (ewbk-6324)
- The rise of Nazism (ewbk-6325)
- Using graphic organisers (ewbk-6326)



MyWorld History Atlas

- The Great Depression

20.8 Thinking Big research project: TV Quizmaster



ProjectsPLUS

- TV Quizmaster (0204)

20.9 Review



eWorkbook

- Reflection (ewbk-6328)
- Crossword (ewbk-6327)
- Student Learning Matrix (ewbk-6319)



Interactivity

- Origins of World War II crossword (int-7661)